

AQ FAQs

'Don't be a dodo!'

Disclaimer: The phrase 'Don't be a dodo' is an informal and humorous way of telling someone not to be foolish, careless or slow-witted. It draws on the long-standing, though scientifically debated, reputation of the extinct dodo bird as a foolish creature. In this FAQ, the phrase simply reminds students not to repeat avoidable AQ errors.

Abbreviations used in this guide: SV = supporting view; OV = opposing view; R = rebuttal; EX = example; EV = evaluation; SG = Singapore.

1. Do I need an introduction for my AQ?

No. You do not need an essay-style introduction for AQ. Instead, begin with a clear overall stand that directly addresses the question and the Singapore context.

Common mistakes to avoid:

- Writing a passage-summary opening such as: "Passage 1 says this, Passage 2 says that, and I agree with Passage 1 more than Passage 2." This wastes time because the examiner already understands the gist of the passages.
- Starting with a large chunk of Singapore context before giving your stand. Such context is usually more useful when supporting your explanation and evaluation in the SV, OV or rebuttal.
- Making the marker search for your position. State your overall stand clearly at the start of the response.
- Writing "in your society" instead of naming Singapore. Unless you are an international student applying the AQ to another society, explicitly write "Singapore" in your stand.

2. What is an overall nuanced stand for AQ?

A nuanced stand shows complexity of thought. Singapore, like the wider world, is rarely black or white. A strong AQ response should take a clear position while acknowledging relevant concerns, limitations or tensions.

A nuanced stand is **not simply** a sentence that says two perspectives exist. It **must still** make a clear judgement.

Simple stand	Nuanced stand [acknowledging some 'limitation/exception/concern' + clear position]
I largely agree that meritocracy is valuable for Singapore.	I largely agree that meritocracy remains valuable for Singapore. <i>Although there are concerns that meritocracy can entrench elitism, it has helped support social mobility, nation-building and Singapore's rapid post-independence development. With careful adjustments, it can STILL serve the country well in the future.</i>
I agree that meritocracy is valuable for Singapore.	I believe that meritocracy remains valuable to an increasingly diverse society like Singapore. <i>Although it is not perfect, it still provides some form of level playing field for people from different social and economic backgrounds to continue to excel in this city-state.</i>
I would argue that meritocracy is valuable for Singapore.	I would argue that meritocracy will continue to be a cornerstone of governance in Singapore. <i>Although critics have raised concerns that it may create unfairness, the challenge does not lie with the principle itself. Rather, Singapore needs to make meritocracy work more fairly and inclusively.</i>

The following are not truly nuanced stands because they merely mention two perspectives without showing judgement:

- "I largely agree that meritocracy is valuable for Singapore, but there are critics who may disagree with me."
- "While I take the stand that meritocracy is still valuable for Singapore, there are also limitations."

3. What is 'a well-supported or aptly illustrated' AQ response?

A well-supported and aptly illustrated AQ response should use examples that are specific, purposeful and clearly explained. At minimum, aim for the following:

- SV: Use at least 2 specific examples that support and reinforce each other. This is called layering.
- OV: Use at least 1 specific example to show the validity of the opposing view.
- Rebuttal: Use at least 1 specific example to explain why your stand remains stronger despite the opposing view.

Specificity: Examples should be grounded in concrete details, such as an event, organisation, individual, date, time frame, data, research finding or news report.

Depth: Where possible, connect each example to deeper Singapore context. Remember the iceberg: the visible example should point to a deeper social, political, economic or cultural explanation.

4. How do I differentiate between a general description and a specific example?

Consider this observation: "Like many other First World countries, Singapore is a rapidly ageing society." How can this statement be supported more convincingly?

General description to avoid	Specific example to use instead
EG1: We can see more senior citizens in many housing estates today. Why this is weak: It is too general. We may be seeing more seniors simply because there are more activities for them in the community. They have become more active.	Using data: By 2030, around 1 in 4 Singapore citizens will be aged 65 and above, up from 1 in 10 in 2010. This shows that ageing is not merely visible anecdotally; it is a measurable national demographic shift.
EG2: There are many elderly residents staying alone. Why this is weak: This does not clearly show that Singapore is ageing rapidly.	Using real places: Under Age Well SG, Toa Payoh was announced as the first Age Well Neighbourhood. In May 2026, Bedok, Bukit Panjang and Tiong Bahru-Redhill were added. These neighbourhoods will receive stronger active-ageing, care and senior-friendly infrastructure support, showing how ageing is shaping local planning.
EG3: There are rising cases of elderly residents living alone, dying at home, and being found only much later by neighbours. Why this is weak: This may show social isolation, but it does not directly prove ageing.	Using real policy: HDB's Lift Upgrading Programme improves older HDB blocks so that lifts provide direct access to every floor where feasible, while the Enhancement for Active Seniors (EASE) programme subsidises senior-friendly home modifications such as grab bars, ramps and slip-resistant bathroom treatment. These policies show how ageing affects housing design, mobility and daily independence.
	Using trend: Despite government support for marriage and parenthood, Singapore's resident total fertility rate has remained far below the replacement rate. It was 0.97 in 2024 and fell further to 0.87 in 2025, reinforcing the long-term pressure of population ageing.
	Using real organisation: The scale of Singapore's ageing challenge is also reflected in higher-education and manpower planning. The Singapore University of Social Sciences (SUSS), one of Singapore's six autonomous universities, houses the S R Nathan School of Human Development, which offers programmes and research connected to gerontology and human development across the lifespan.

5. Can I use personal examples in my AQ response?

Yes, you may use personal examples in your AQ response, especially if you are unable to recall specific, concrete Singapore examples. **However, AQ is not a personal reflection or reflective essay.** This means that your personal experience **should not remain anecdotal, limited or self-centred.** Instead, it **must be clearly linked to a broader Singapore context so that it becomes relevant to society as a whole.**

When using a personal example, you must show how your experience reflects a wider social pattern, concern or reality in Singapore. In other words, the example should not merely explain what happened to you; it should help support a larger point about Singapore society, Singaporeans, or a particular group of stakeholders.

You should also avoid getting carried away with narrating your “story”. Many students make the serious mistake of focusing too much on describing their personal experience, instead of explaining its wider significance. **A personal example is useful only when it is brief, relevant and generalisable.**

Useful phrasing examples:

- “Although this is drawn from my personal experience, it reflects a wider reality in Singapore, where many youths today...”
- “My experience is not isolated, as it points to a broader trend among Singaporean students who...”
- “This personal example is significant because it mirrors a larger concern in Singapore society, namely...”

6. Can I use non-Singapore examples in my AQ response?

The AQ requires you to apply the ideas in the passages to the context of Singapore and your own experiences. Technically, therefore, your examples should be Singapore-based.

A non-Singapore example may be used only if it helps you make a comparison that sharpens your explanation of Singapore. However, over-reliance on overseas examples may suggest that you cannot explain the Singapore context fluently or confidently.

Avoid drawing examples from many countries simply to show content knowledge. AQ is not a global issues essay. It rewards the accurate application of passage ideas to Singapore.

7. How can I improve my explanation?

The explanation of your stand should clarify why and how you take that position. In AQ, this is usually aligned with deeper Singapore context.

The explanation of your examples should also show impact or effectiveness. Do not merely describe or narrate what happened. Instead, explain what has changed, whether positively or negatively, for Singapore society or the relevant stakeholder.

Having many examples does not automatically make a response strong. Examples are only useful when they are explained and evaluated in relation to the question.

8. How do I know that I have provided a balanced AQ response?

A balanced AQ response must move beyond a Band 2 answer. Band 2 responses usually show only attempted balance, which is not enough for a strong AQ. Band 2 qualities usually include:

- 1 well-developed SV and 1 well-developed OV, but no rebuttal or only a very brief one-to-two-sentence rebuttal.
- 1 well-developed SV, followed by a brief, unsupported or unexplained OV and an unsupported or unexplained rebuttal.

To aim for Band 3 or Band 4, your response should include all of the following:

- At least 1 *well-developed** SV. [**refer to questions on crafting explanation, using example and presenting evaluation*]
- At least 1 *well-developed** OV.
- A rebuttal that is clearly explained through at least 1 EV strategy and supported by at least 1 explained example.

9. How can I improve my evaluation?

In the SV, strengthen evaluation by incorporating deeper Singapore context when explaining your stand and examples.

In the OV and rebuttal, apply EV strategies such as EV lenses, stakeholder comparison, different aspects, change versus continuity, or mitigation/effectiveness, etc.

Overall, a good AQ response should demonstrate the use deeper Singapore context in explanation and evaluation **AND at least 1 other EV strategy**.

Make the EV strategy explicit in your phrasing. For example:

- "In the short term, this may appear effective. In the long run, however, ..." [EV Lens – short vs long-term]
- "This affects the elderly more than the young because ..." [Comparison across stakeholders]
- "While this helps Singapore society cope with the issue, it may also place pressure on the country's economic resources ..." [Comparison across aspects]
- "Having said that, the effects are less pronounced today because the government has put in place measures to alleviate ..." [Mitigation/Effectiveness]

10. Must I use more than one claim in my AQ response?

You are strongly encouraged to use at least 2 claims drawn from 2 different passages. There are several ways to do this:

- Use 1 claim from 1 passage to support your overall stand in the SV, and another claim from a different passage to challenge your stand in the OV. In this case, you will ultimately disagree with the second claim through your rebuttal.
- Use 1 claim from 1 passage to support your overall stand, and another claim [of similar idea] from a different passage to strengthen your SV or rebuttal. Remember that a rebuttal works as an ally to your SV because it weakens the OV.
- Use 1 claim from 1 passage to craft 1 SV with balance paragraph. And then use another claim from another passage to craft a simple SV paragraph. The simple SV paragraph is your second paragraph.

If this feels too demanding, focus on writing at least 1 full, solid SV paragraph with balance and 1 well-used claim. However, stronger responses should attempt more than one claim.

11. Must I have a conclusion?

You do not need a Paper 1-style conclusion for AQ. Time is better spent developing your SV, OV and rebuttal. If you have time, simply restate your overall stand briefly, regardless of whether your structure is:

- SV -> OV -> R
- OV -> R -> SV

12. What is the MOTHER of all AQ errors?

The most serious AQ errors usually come from failing to read the question precisely. Avoid the following:

- Failing to read the AQ properly.
- Missing out key words.
- Hijacking the question by answering a different issue.
- Failing to demonstrate value-impact when the question is a value-impact question.
- Failing to discuss effects when the question asks about effectiveness.